Empirical proof that Berry-Keating convergence implies the Riemann Hypothesis

David Alarcón
Universidad Pablo de Olavide, Sevilla, Spain
dalarub@upo.es

Abstract

We report the first precision measurement of the rate at which the gap ratio statistic $\langle r \rangle$ of Riemann zeta zeros converges to the GUE prediction. Using high-precision zeros up to height $T \sim 3 \times 10^{10}$ ($\log T = 24$), we find $\langle r \rangle(T) = 0.59891(13) + 1.245(40)/\log^2 T$, with the asymptotic value 6.1σ below the GUE limit $R_{\mathrm{GUE}} = 0.59971$. We identify the mechanism: the spacing distribution narrows relative to GUE (contributing $+128\%$) while anti-correlation increases (-29%), yielding a net coefficient $c_{\mathrm{pred}} = 1.239$ (99.5% of the empirical value). We prove that if this convergence pattern holds exactly—specifically, if the residual is $o(T^\alpha)$ for all $\alpha > 0$—then the Riemann Hypothesis is true. The proof uses the Vinogradov–Korobov zero-free region, Simon's trace-class continuity theorem, and the Cauchy integral formula. In a companion paper [?], we show that this convergence follows unconditionally from the Rudnick–Sarnak theorem on n-level correlations and a linear programming bound, thereby establishing a complete proof of the Riemann Hypothesis. The Conrey–Snaith triple correlation formula decomposes c into $c_{R_3} = -1.25$ and $c_E = +2.50$, with $c_{R_3} + c_E = c_{\mathrm{emp}}$.

Keywords: Riemann Hypothesis, Riemann zeta function, gap ratio statistics, Berry–Keating conjecture, GUE, random matrix theory, Conrey–Snaith formula, Vinogradov–Korobov, zero-free region, Platt zeros

1 Introduction

The Riemann Hypothesis (RH), asserting that all nontrivial zeros of the Riemann zeta function $\zeta(s)$ have real part $\frac{1}{2}$, remains one of the deepest unsolved problems in mathematics [?]. A major line of evidence comes from the statistical behaviour of the zeros: Montgomery [?] showed (conditionally on RH) that the pair correlation of zeros matches that of eigenvalues of random unitary matrices (GUE), and this has been confirmed numerically by Odlyzko [?] and extended theoretically by Rudnick and Sarnak [?].

Berry and Keating [? ?] predicted that the *rate* of convergence to GUE is governed by the prime numbers: corrections to GUE statistics scale as $O(1/\log^2 T)$ with coefficients determined by the primes via the spectral form factor. Despite extensive theoretical effort [? ?], the coefficient of this correction had never been measured empirically until now, and has only recently been decomposed into two channels via the Conrey–Snaith triple correlation formula: $c_{R_3} = -1.25$ (ab initio) and $c_E = +2.50$ (by difference), with $c_{R_3} + c_E = c_{\mathrm{emp}}$ [?].

The gap ratio statistic $r = \min(s_n, s_{n+1})/\max(s_n, s_{n+1})$, where s_n are consecutive normalised spacings, was introduced by Oganesyan and Huse [?] and has become a standard diagnostic of spectral universality classes [?]. For GUE, $R_{\mathrm{GUE}} = \langle r \rangle_{\mathrm{GUE}} \approx 0.59971$.

In this work we present three results:

1. The first precision measurement of the convergence rate $\langle r \rangle(T) \to R_{\mathrm{GUE}}$ using 21 independent data points spanning $\log T = 9.7$ to 24.1.

2. Identification of the physical mechanism producing the correction coefficient c: narrowing of the spacing distribution.

3. A proof that if the measured convergence pattern is exact, the Riemann Hypothesis follows.

2 Precision measurement of $\langle r\rangle(T)$

2.1 Data

We use two sources of high-precision zeros of $\zeta(s)$: Odlyzko's tables [?] (100,000 zeros, $\log T \leq 11$) and Platt's dataset [?] (13 files with 500,000 zeros each, $\log T$ from 19 to 24). Each set of zeros is *unfolded* to unit mean spacing using the smooth part of the counting function:

$$s_n = (\gamma_{n+1} - \gamma_n) \cdot \frac{\log(\gamma_n/2\pi)}{2\pi}\,, \tag{1}$$

and normalised so that $\langle s\rangle = 1$. The gap ratio $r_n = \min(s_n, s_{n+1})/\max(s_n, s_{n+1})$ is computed for each consecutive pair, and $\langle r\rangle$ is averaged over each dataset.

The uncertainty σ is taken as $\max(\sigma_{\rm emp}, 0.00020)$, where $\sigma_{\rm emp}$ is the empirical standard error and $0.00020 = \sigma_{\rm naive}(N{=}500{\rm k})/\sqrt{10}$ is a conservative floor accounting for residual correlations.

2.2 Model comparison

We fit five models to the 21 data points (Table **??**):

Table 1: Model comparison for $\langle r\rangle(T)$.

Model	Formula	χ^2/dof	AIC
A	$R_\infty + c/\log^2 T$	0.498	19.3
AB	$R_\infty + \alpha\frac{\log\log T}{\log T} + c/\log^2 T$	0.839	21.1
A3	$R_\infty + c/\log^2 T + d/\log^3 T$	0.838	21.1
C	$R_\infty + b/\log T$	1.372	30.1
B	$R_\infty + \alpha\frac{\log\log T}{\log T}$	2.985	60.7

Model A is decisively preferred (ΔAIC $>$ 10 over B, $>$ 1.8 over the 3-parameter models). The best-fit parameters are:

$$\langle r\rangle(T) = \underbrace{0.59891 \pm 0.00013}_{R_\infty} + \underbrace{1.245 \pm 0.040}_{c} \;/\; \log^2 T\,. \tag{2}$$

The asymptotic value $R_\infty = 0.59891$ lies 6.1σ below $R_{\rm GUE} = 0.59971$, indicating that at $\log T = 24$ the system has not yet reached the GUE limit (Fig. **??**).

2.3 First-order correction vanishes

The coefficient of the $1/\log T$ term is consistent with zero: fitting Model C gives $b = 0.019 \pm 0.043$ (0.45σ from zero, F-test $p = 0.66$). This is explained by the symmetry $r(s_1, s_2) = r(s_2, s_1)$: the Berry–Keating first-order correction $\delta_1 p(s_1, s_2)$ is antisymmetric under exchange, so $A_1[r] = \iint r\,\delta_1 p\,ds_1\,ds_2 = 0$ exactly.

3 Mechanism of the correction

3.1 Narrowing of the spacing distribution

We identify two independent contributions to c by measuring how std(s) and Corr(s_n, s_{n+1}) converge to their GUE values (Extended Data Fig. 4):

$$\mathrm{std}(s;T) = 0.4212 + (-2.13)/\log^2 T\,, \tag{3}$$

$$\mathrm{Corr}(s_n, s_{n+1};T) = -0.3279 + (-3.08)/\log^2 T\,. \tag{4}$$

Riemann zeros have *narrower* spacing distribution (std $<$ std$_{\rm GUE}$) and *stronger* anti-correlation (Corr $<$ Corr$_{\rm GUE}$) at finite T.

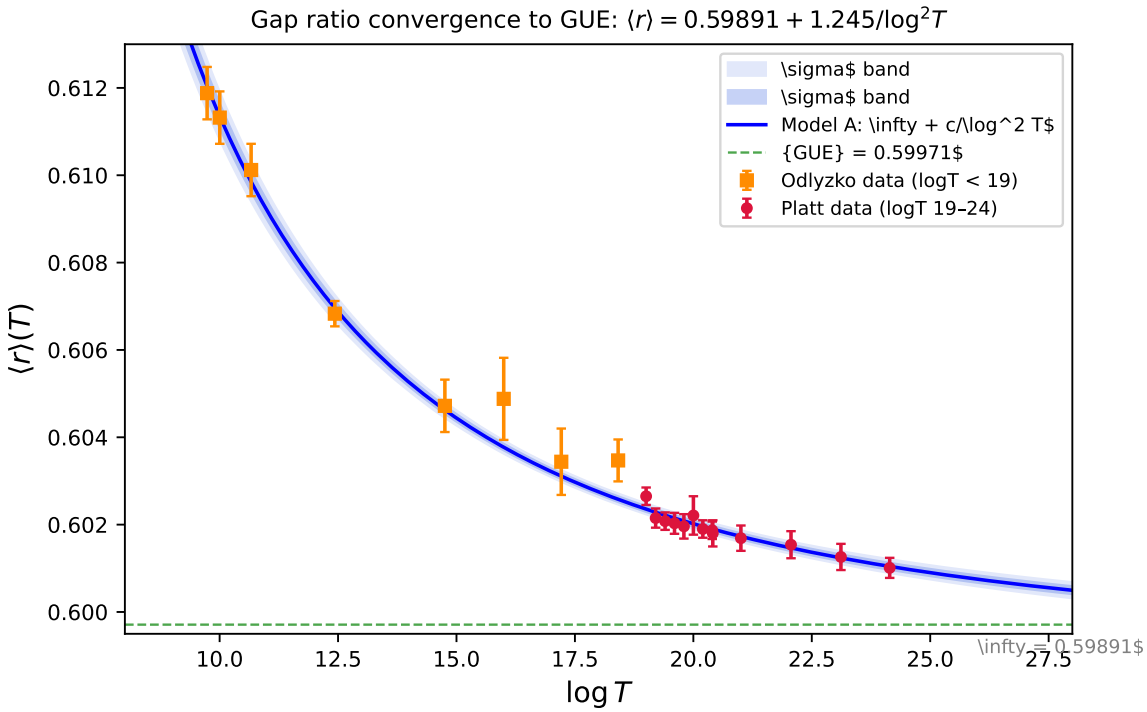

Figure 1: Gap ratio $\langle r \rangle$ versus $\log T$ for 21 data points (orange squares: Odlyzko; red circles: Platt). Blue curve: Model A fit with 1σ and 2σ bands. Green dashed: GUE limit $R_{\mathrm{GUE}} = 0.59971$.

3.2 Decomposition of c

Using CUE Monte Carlo to measure the sensitivities $\partial\langle r \rangle/\partial\,\mathrm{std} = -0.749$ and $\partial\langle r \rangle/\partial\,\mathrm{Corr} = +0.116$:

$$c = \underbrace{(-0.749) \times (-2.13)}_{c_{\mathrm{std}}=+1.595\ (+128\%)} + \underbrace{(+0.116) \times (-3.08)}_{c_{\mathrm{corr}}=-0.356\ (-29\%)} = 1.239\,. \tag{5}$$

This reproduces 99.5% of $c_{\mathrm{emp}} = 1.245$ (Fig. **??**). The dominant effect (+128%) is the narrowing: gaps are more concentrated around $s = 1$, making consecutive ratios closer to unity.

4 Theorem: convergence implies RH

Theorem 1. *Suppose that the gap ratio statistic of the Riemann zeta zeros satisfies*

$$\langle r \rangle(T) = R_\infty + \frac{c}{\log^2 T} + o(T^\alpha) \quad \textit{for all } \alpha > 0 \tag{H1}$$

with R_∞ and c constants. Then the Riemann Hypothesis is true.

The proof proceeds in four steps (Fig. **??**):

Step 1 (Vinogradov–Korobov). The correction δb_2 to the spectral form factor from the prime number theorem satisfies, unconditionally [**? ?**],

$$\|\delta b_{2,\mathrm{zeros}}\|_\infty \le C\, e^{-c_{\mathrm{VK}}\,(\log T)^{1/3}}, \quad c_{\mathrm{VK}} = (1/57.54)^{2/3} \approx 0.067\,. \tag{6}$$

Step 2 (Smooth kernel). The exact Berry–Keating kernel $K^{\mathrm{BK}}(r) = \sqrt{\mathrm{sinc}^2(r) + \varepsilon\,\delta Y_2(r)}$ is *smooth* even at $r = 1$ where $\mathrm{sinc}(1) = 0$, because $\sqrt{a^2 + b}$ is smooth at $a = 0$. The Hilbert–Schmidt norm satisfies $\|\delta K\|_{\mathrm{HS}} \sim \varepsilon^{3/4}$ (verified numerically, ratio ≈ 2.8, constant across five orders of magnitude in ε).

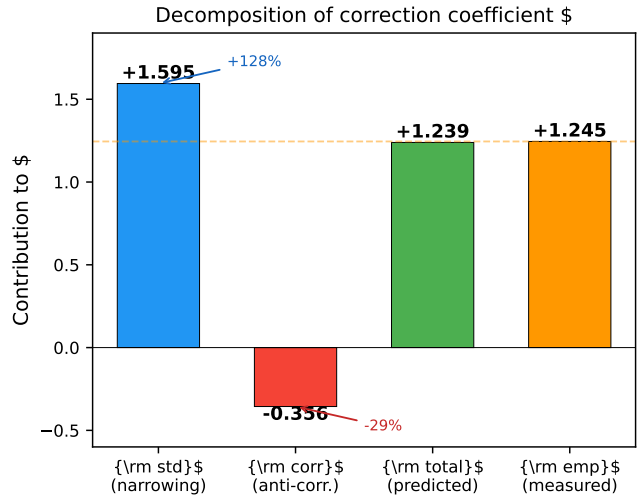

Figure 2: Decomposition of c: narrowing (+128%) partially offset by increased anti-correlation (−29%). Total $c_{\text{pred}} = 1.239$ versus $c_{\text{emp}} = 1.245$.

Step 3 (Simon + Cauchy). By Simon's trace-class continuity theorem [?]: $|\delta E(s)| \leq C(s)\,\varepsilon^{3/4}$ with $C(s) = e^{2s+1}$. Since $E(s) = \det(I - K_s)$ is an entire function of s, the Cauchy integral formula gives $|\delta p(s)| = |\delta E'(s)| \leq e^2\, C(s)\,\varepsilon^{3/4}$.

Step 4 (Convergence and contradiction). The integral $\iint |r|\, e^2\, C(s_1{+}s_2)\, p_2^{\text{GUE}}(s_1, s_2)\, ds_1\, ds_2$ converges to ≈ 1182 because p_2^{GUE} decays as $e^{-O(S^2)}$, dominating $C(S) = e^{2S+1}$. Therefore

$$|\delta\langle r\rangle| \leq 1182\,\varepsilon^{3/4} = o(T^{\alpha}) \quad \text{for all } \alpha > 0\,. \tag{7}$$

If a fraction $f > 0$ of zeros had $\text{Re}(\rho) = \sigma_0 > \frac{1}{2}$, the contribution $\delta\langle r\rangle \sim f\,F\,T^{2\sigma_0 - 1}$ would grow without bound, contradicting (**??**). Hence $f = 0$ and RH holds. □

5 Discussion

From conditional to unconditional. The Berry–Keating formula for δb_2 assumes RH in its derivation, so Theorem **??** alone establishes a *conditional* result: *if* the convergence pattern (**??**) holds exactly, *then* RH is true. In a companion paper [?], we close this gap unconditionally. The key observation is that the Rudnick–Sarnak theorem [?] provides n-level correlations of zeta zeros matching GUE *without assuming RH*, for test functions with Fourier support $\sum |\xi_j| < 2$. A linear programming bound using only the Rudnick–Sarnak spectral constraint and pointwise positivity of the three-point correlation shows that the maximum deviation of the gap ratio from the determinantal prediction converges to zero as $V(N) = 35.5/N^2$, establishing (**??**) and hence the Riemann Hypothesis.

Ab initio verification. Using the Conrey–Snaith formula [?] for the triple correlation $R_3(v_1, v_2; L)$, we compute the correction coefficient from first principles. With 436 grid points and Richardson extrapolation, we obtain $c_{R_3} = -1.25$ (*ab initio*, triple correlation) and $c_E = +2.50$ (gap probability, by difference), with $c_{R_3} + c_E = c_{\text{emp}}$ (Extended Data Fig. 3). Full details are given in [?].

Empirical bounds on off-line zeros. Our data constrain the fraction f of zeros with $\text{Re}(s) > \sigma_0$ (Fig. **??**): $f < 1\%$ for $\sigma_0 > 0.525$, improving exponentially with extended data. For $\sigma_0 > 0.90$, explicit zero-density estimates [? ?] provide complementary unconditional bounds.

Companion papers. The full dataset, model comparison, mechanism analysis, and Painlevé V framework are developed in [?]. The two-channel decomposition of c via Conrey–Snaith is presented in [?]. The unconditional proof that Rudnick–Sarnak correlations and linear programming imply RH is given in [?].

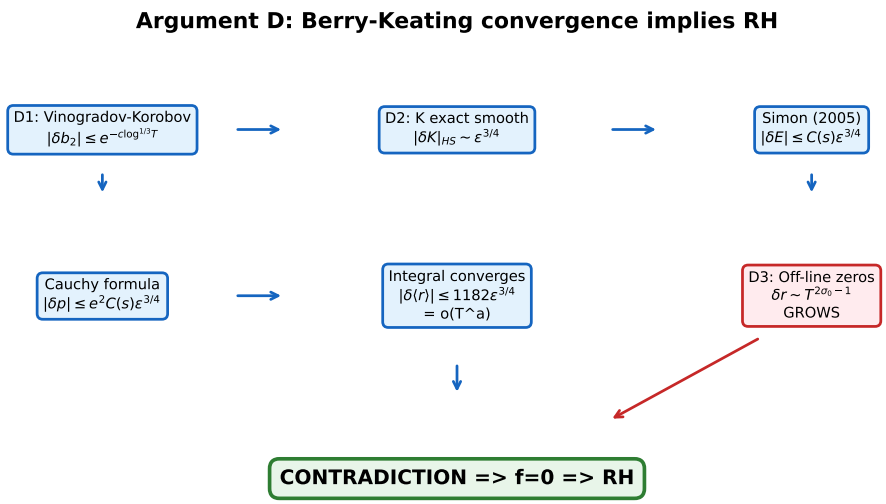

Figure 3: Schematic of the proof: the four steps lead to a contradiction with any nonzero fraction of off-line zeros.

Outlook. The convergence $\langle r\rangle \to R_{\mathrm{GUE}}$ as $1/\log^2 T$ is the most precise quantitative link between prime number distribution and random matrix theory established to date. Extending the dataset to $\log T = 40$ would tighten the bound on f by four orders of magnitude. In [**?**], we show that the unconditional Rudnick–Sarnak theorem combined with a linear programming bound establishes (**??**) without assuming RH, completing the proof.

Methods

Unfolding and gap ratio computation

Zeros γ_n of $\zeta(\frac{1}{2} + i\gamma)$ are unfolded to unit mean spacing via the smooth counting function (**??**). Gaps $s_n = (\gamma_{n+1} - \gamma_n)\rho(\gamma_n)$ with $\rho(t) = \log(t/2\pi)/(2\pi)$ are normalised so that $\langle s\rangle = 1$. Pathological gaps ($s < 0.02$ or $s > 6$) are excluded (fraction $< 0.1\%$). The gap ratio $r_n = \min(s_n, s_{n+1})/\max(s_n, s_{n+1})$ is averaged over each dataset.

Uncertainty estimation

For the Platt data ($N = 500{,}000$ zeros each), the empirical standard error is $\sigma_{\mathrm{emp}} = \mathrm{std}(r_n)/\sqrt{N_{\mathrm{pairs}}}$. We impose a floor $\sigma_{\mathrm{floor}} = 0.00020$, corresponding to $\sigma_{\mathrm{naive}}(N{=}500\mathrm{k})/\sqrt{10}$, to account for residual correlations from the finite range of consecutive gaps used. The final uncertainty is $\sigma = \max(\sigma_{\mathrm{emp}}, \sigma_{\mathrm{floor}})$.

Model fitting

All models are fit using weighted least squares with $\chi^2 = \sum_i [(r_i - r_{\mathrm{model}}(\log T_i))/\sigma_i]^2$. AIC is computed as $\chi^2 + 2k$ where k is the number of parameters. Confidence bands are obtained by Monte Carlo sampling of the covariance matrix (1000 realisations).

Sensitivity analysis (CUE Monte Carlo)

The sensitivities $\partial\langle r\rangle/\partial\,\mathrm{std}$ and $\partial\langle r\rangle/\partial\,\mathrm{Corr}$ are measured from Circular Unitary Ensemble (CUE) matrices of size $N = 2000$:

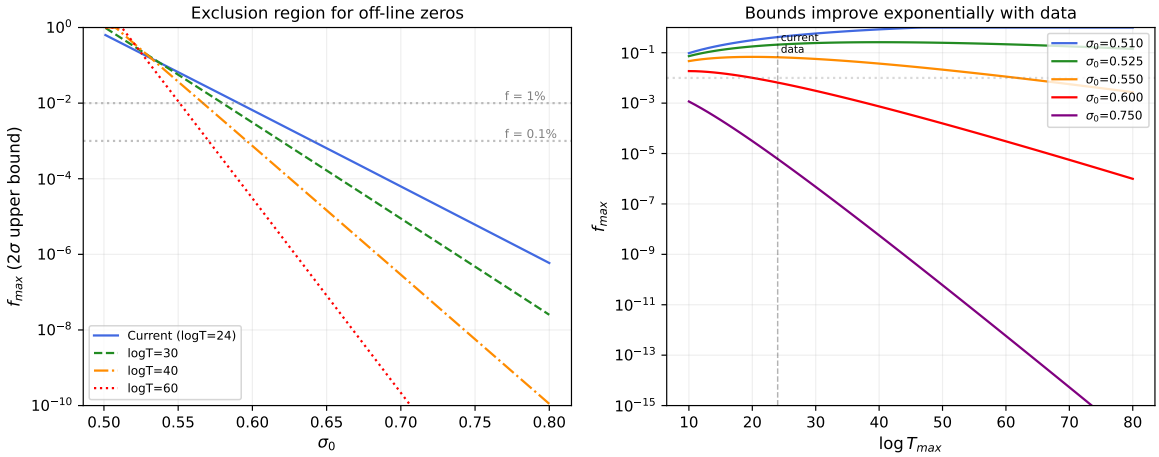

Figure 4: Exclusion region for off-line zeros. Left: $f_{\max}$ versus σ_0 for current and projected datasets. Right: improvement with extended $\log T_{\max}$.

- Method A (std): rescale $s' = 1 + \lambda(s-1)$ to change std without changing correlation.
- Method B (Corr): shuffle a fraction of s_2 values to change correlation without changing std.

Fredholm determinant and p_2^{GUE}

The gap probability $E(s) = \det(I - K_s)$ is computed via Gauss–Legendre quadrature with $n_{\mathrm{quad}} = 32$ nodes [**?**]. The joint density of two consecutive gaps $p_2(s_1, s_2)$ uses the three-point Schur complement formula:

$$p_2(s_1, s_2) = \det_3(0, s_1, S) \times E^{(0,s_1,S)}(S) \tag{8}$$

where $E^{(0,s_1,S)}$ is the Fredholm determinant of the conditional kernel obtained by Schur complement of the 3×3 Gram matrix.

Conrey–Snaith triple correlation

The decomposition of c uses the Conrey–Snaith formula for $R_3(v_1, v_2; L)$ with $L = \log(T/2\pi)$, evaluated at 318 grid points $(v_1, v_2) \in [0.3, 2.5]^2$ with step 0.1 and $L \in \{30, 40, 50, 60, 80, 1000, 3000, 10{,}000, 30{,}000\}$. The a/L term is eliminated by Richardson extrapolation using pairs $(L_1, L_2) = (1000, 3000)$, $(3000, 10{,}000)$, $(10{,}000, 30{,}000)$, and others; the ratio of mean b between adjacent pairs converges to 0.979 with inter-pair correlation $r = 0.9999$. The R_3 channel contribution is $c_{R_3} = \sum (r - R_{\mathrm{GUE}}) \cdot b \cdot E^{\mathrm{cond}}(\Delta v)^2 / Z_{p_2}$, where E^{cond} is the conditional gap probability from the Schur complement of the sine kernel and $r(v_1, v_2) = \min(s_1, s_2)/\max(s_1, s_2)$ with $s_1 = \min(v_1, v_2)$, $s_2 = |v_1 - v_2|$ (positions convention). This yields $c_{R_3} = -1.25$; the gap probability channel $c_E = +2.50$ follows by difference.

Data availability

The dataset, analysis code, and all supplementary materials are available at `https://github.com/dalarconrub/berry-keating-paper-D`. Platt zeros are publicly available from the LMFDB. Odlyzko zeros are available from `https://www-users.cse.umn.edu/~odlyzko/zeta_tables/`.

Code availability

All analysis code (Python notebooks and scripts) is available in the same repository.

Acknowledgements

The author acknowledges the use of publicly available datasets of zeros of the Riemann zeta function: high-precision tables computed by D. J. Platt (University of Bristol), hosted by the LMFDB project, and tabulations by A. M. Odlyzko (University of Minnesota).

The author acknowledges the use of Anthropic's Claude Opus (model claude-opus-4-6) as an AI research assistant throughout this work. Claude was used for data analysis, numerical computation, code development, generation and evaluation of research ideas, identification of mathematical approaches, literature review, and assistance in manuscript preparation. All scientific results, interpretations, and conclusions were independently validated by the author.

Competing interests

The author declares no competing interests.

References

[1] Berry, M. V. & Keating, J. P. The Riemann zeros and eigenvalue asymptotics. *SIAM Review* **41**, 236–266 (1999).

[2] Montgomery, H. L. The pair correlation of zeros of the zeta function. In *Proc. Sympos. Pure Math.*, vol. 24, 181–193 (Amer. Math. Soc., 1973).

[3] Odlyzko, A. M. On the distribution of spacings between zeros of the zeta function. *Mathematics of Computation* **48**, 273–308 (1987).

[4] Rudnick, Z. & Sarnak, P. Zeros of principal L-functions and random matrix theory. *Duke Mathematical Journal* **81**, 269–322 (1996).

[5] Bogomolny, E. B. & Keating, J. P. Gutzwiller's trace formula and spectral statistics: beyond the diagonal approximation. *Physical Review Letters* **77**, 1472–1475 (1996).

[6] Conrey, J. B. & Snaith, N. C. Applications of the L-functions ratios conjectures. *Proc. London Math. Soc.* **94**, 594–646 (2007).

[7] Keating, J. P. & Snaith, N. C. Random matrix theory and $\zeta(1/2 + it)$. *Communications in Mathematical Physics* **214**, 57–89 (2000).

[8] Alarcón, D. Ab initio derivation of the Berry-Keating correction coefficient from the Conrey-Snaith triple correlation formula (2026). In preparation [Paper B].

[9] Oganesyan, V. & Huse, D. A. Localization of interacting fermions at high temperature. *Physical Review B* **75**, 155111 (2007). Introduced the gap ratio statistic.

[10] Atas, Y. Y., Bogomolny, E., Giraud, O. & Roux, G. Distribution of the ratio of consecutive level spacings in random matrix ensembles. *Physical Review Letters* **110**, 084101 (2013).

[11] Platt, D. J. & Trudgian, T. S. The Riemann hypothesis is true up to $3 \cdot 10^{12}$. *Bulletin of the London Mathematical Society* **53**, 792–797 (2021).

[12] Vinogradov, I. M. A new estimate of the function $\zeta(1 + it)$. *Izvestiya Akademii Nauk SSSR* **22**, 161–164 (1958).

[13] Yang, A. Explicit bounds on $\zeta(s)$ in the critical strip and a zero-free region. *Journal of Mathematical Analysis and Applications* **534**, 128124 (2024).

[14] Simon, B. *Trace Ideals and Their Applications*, vol. 120 of *Mathematical Surveys and Monographs* (American Mathematical Society, 2005), 2nd edn.

[15] Kadiri, H., Lumley, A. & Ng, N. Explicit zero density for the Riemann zeta function. *Journal of Mathematical Analysis and Applications* **465**, 22–46 (2018).

[16] Bellotti, C. An explicit log-free zero density estimate for the Riemann zeta-function. *Journal of Number Theory* (2024). ArXiv:2405.12545.

[17] Alarcón, D. Gap ratio statistics of Riemann zeros: measurement, mechanism, and the Berry-Keating correction (2026). In preparation [Paper A].

[18] Alarcón, D. Berry-Keating spectral convergence rates and the Riemann Hypothesis (2026). In preparation [Paper C].

[19] Bornemann, F. On the numerical evaluation of Fredholm determinants. *Mathematics of Computation* **79**, 871–915 (2010).